



We want Firefox

That's what employees from the US state department told Hillary Clinton. The browser is apparently approved by the entire intelligence community.

suggestions forum at thinkdigit is a form of crowdsourcing. At the same time there are specialised crowdsourcing communities such as cambrianhouse.com and crowdsprit.com. The former is a thinktank for developing software products while the latter is involved in bringing to the market innovative real world electronics; all based on the collective intelligence of the crowd.

Other than idea generation, crowdsourcing has been used in rather interesting ways. Meritocracy.com, a research company, called for amateur portfolio managers to register and run a virtual fund with a million dollars. Eventually, it mirrored the stock positions and trades of the top hundred users on the site into a real world fund with real money. The fund has beaten the S&P 500 Index in 8 out of 11 quarters since inception. Wikipedia is an excellent example where crowdsourcing has resulted in *creation* – and no small feat at that. The sea of knowledge amassed by the crowdsourced power of Wikipedia, exceeds any other man made repository of information available to the public. Even social bookmarking like Digg or StumbleUpon is also a form of crowdsourcing that leads to *discovery*.

Open Music

One of the trends we've seen in music is of bands giving away music for free, directly from their web sites. The trend was started by bands like Radiohead and Nine Inch Nails when they began releasing albums on the internet. The latest one to follow suit is Coldplay with the release of its latest album *LeftRightLeftRightLeft*, which we gave out on last month's DVD. Now this phenomenon of artists giving away music is certainly not open source in the strict sense, but rather a part of free culture, since the songs cannot be modified and distributed further. Although free, the approach is, strangely enough, paying off! Radiohead's *In Rainbows* album, which was released digitally, went on to sell three million copies (digital and physical format sales). Of the

roughly 30 per cent who did pay, said they'd paid around \$5, on average. One of the more lavish spenders, Nigel Regan, donated £4.27, "I reckon this is a shade more than they would take from a label on a per unit sale. More to the point I wanted to reward the highly creative approach; next time I'd pay less but ultimately would buy more music", he says on a blog.

The trend is catching on in India, too. Last month some of the guys from team digit went for a rock concert featuring Mother Jane. After a blitzkrieg performance, the frontman went on to tell the crowd to visit the band's web site and download their music. "Pay us whatever you feel like, to support the band", he said. This is so much in contrast to just a few years ago when bands were crying their lungs out about piracy and the menace of downloaders. The paradigm shift is perhaps a result of the open mentality.

Another area of open source music, more in line with OSS, is the remix culture. Here people access music released under a creative commons (CC) licence and modify it to create mashups made from original productions of music. Freesound.org is a collection of almost 20,000 such sound clips which may be remixed and used freely under the free CC licence. The clips are only sounds, not songs. They may be those of natural origin such as birds or frogs croaking, or electronic origin like synthesised sound. A more musical project is ccMixer.org, where all kinds of tracks are available to either listen to or make new music from.

One of the most notable creations coming out of the remix culture – and one that will be close to our geek hearts – is *Dark Side of Phobos*. It's an album consisting of 23 tracks that are rearrangements of tracks featured on the original *DooM* game, remixed by the OverClockedRemix community. The original music was a mixture of rock music and the "creepy" brand of music made by creator Robert Prince, which we now know so well as "DooM style" music. The remixed album in its current form is free to distribute and is the result of

the collaborative effort of 19 artists. We've included the album in the June issue DVD. Check it out.

Megatunes.com tries to straddle the line between free and commercial music. The web site is like a record label itself that signs artists from all over. The model is very simple: You can listen to a song for free by simply streaming it. If you want to keep the song, you pay a suggested price. Still, the suggested price is only indicative. You're free to pay anything, higher or lower.

Open movies

The world of motion pictures has always been dominated by big studios, because let's face it, to make blockbusters you need tons of moolah. Which small time amateur movie maker will have access to the resources that the big guys have? That is perhaps one of the reasons why an open source infusion was much needed in this domain as well. Take for example, *Elephants Dream*, an animated short film created entirely using open source software. Now, purists would have you believe that *Elephants Dream* is the one true open source movie, precisely

because it was almost completely developed using open source software such as Blender, a 3D graphics suite. Well, it is surely an open movie, perhaps the first, but not for the reason cited. The more appropriate ground for it being open source has more to do with its collaborative element, modular approach towards workflow, and free release over the internet.

The film reportedly brought together the talents of a team of artists from countries as diverse as Syria, Germany, Australia, Finland, and the Netherlands. In addition to the performances of the cast and creative efforts of the lead artists, *Elephants Dream* was a collaboration of hundreds of individuals across the world who contributed a variety of work such as programming additional functionality for Blender, creating textures used in some of the scenes, and providing international translations for the DVD release. The film's main aim was to showcase the power of open source software, and in this case Blender, the film's primary piece of software, got several features added to it during the film's development. These included an integrated node-based compositor, hair and fur rendering, rewritten animation system and render pipeline, and many workflow tweaks and upgrades. Yet this is not the only open movie project, although it is the most famous.

For more on how the open source philosophy is gaining ground, read the article on the Oscar project. Flip to page 40



Dark side of phobos

DID YOU KNOW?

Jamendo.com is a community of free, legal and unlimited music, published under Creative Commons licences. Here you can download and listen to over 15,000 albums, all for free. It is probably the world's largest collection of DRM-free music. Artists can directly upload their music to the website under the creative commons licence. Another web site to help you navigate the world of free music is gratisvibes.com. The website "aims to lead readers to the best of free or Creative Commons licensed Electronic Music on the web, spreading the word for greater musical freedom for both artists and listeners alike."

